



Return of the King?

The latest Long-Term Support (LTS) release from Canonical, Ubuntu 10.04 Lucid Lynx, was released on April 29, 2010. With refreshing new artwork, and a plethora of features and changes, Ubuntu seems to be trying to take on Mac OSX in the looks department.

When, finally, release day came, Ubuntu hit a bug which delayed the release schedule by a day. When the ISOs were made public, I grabbed the x86_64 Ubuntu-Desktop ISO and burnt it to disk. The desktop I used to test Lucid had an AMD Phenom II X4 B50 @ 3.8 GHz; 4 GB DDR2 RAM @ 900 MHz; an ATI HD 3300 IGP; a Samsung S2233SW Full HD 1080p monitor and a WD 640AAKS hard disk. I also used a bunch of laptops to test Lucid: an Acer Aspire 5740G, and a Dell Inspiron 1410 and Studio 1450.

First boot and installation

The boot screen by default doesn't show any menu options, but as soon as you hit a key, the Live CD options are displayed. The rusty-orange look is gone, replaced with a soothing purple.

You find the first improvements as soon as you begin booting: the much-hyped Plymouth provides a pleasing boot-splash that distracts you from the sluggish Live CD performance. The latest open-source video drivers enable compositing without the need for proprietary drivers. The artwork has changed

and improved; the two new themes, Ambiance and Radiance, gel well with the purplish wallpaper. The background is a nice blend of purple, black and white. A refined new icon theme adds to the eye-candy. The Ayatana project, which debuted with Ubuntu 9.10, looks much more elegant in this release. The panel system tray looks good; the icons look engraved onto the panel. Ubuntu hardware support has come a long way; everything worked right out of the box, and my monitor was automatically set to the optimal resolution.

Moving on to the installation: the allegiant installer hasn't yet got a face-lift; however, the installation slides come with a clean, new look. The installation was swift, with no issues, and in almost all cases completed in a mere 8 minutes. The installer now allows you to encrypt your home folder during installation itself.

On the first post-installation boot, I found there were no icons on the desktop, so the first thing I did was to enable icons using *gconf-editor*. Lucid boots to the login screen considerably faster than older versions, but does take some time to display the desktop fully. That done, however, the system feels fast and responsive.